From Keeping Documents to Understanding History

Rethinking the Archival Profession and Archives

At first, I did not understand why archivists needed to know what researchers were thinking about. I saw their work as similar to a manager's: keeping documents, arranging access, and retrieving materials according to users' needs. As long as nothing was lost and materials were easy to find, the job seemed complete. So when I read the phrase "research partner," my first response was a series of questions: How could someone unfamiliar with my topic take part in my research? If archivists also interpreted materials, how did their work differ from that of historians?[1] These questions seemed to concern professional duties, but they rested on an assumption I had not noticed: I placed research after obtaining materials and treated the work that helped me obtain them as outside research.

The learning in Weeks 7–10 gradually showed me the limits of this assumption. I began to ask why materials existed in their present form and who made it possible for me to find and understand them. As these questions developed, I gained a clearer picture of archivists: they study how collections took shape, assess relationships between records, and help different people understand those relationships. My changing view of the profession involved more than adding a few duties to a list. I began to understand that historical research can take different forms. Archival work therefore became a career path I could seriously consider when thinking about the options open to historical researchers.

This change led to a second question: if understanding materials is already part of the job, what kinds of materials do archivists need to understand? Leaflets, clothing, memories connected to homes, and original documents given public significance made "archives," a term I thought I knew, less straightforward. I needed to reconsider what could count as archives and why. But I want to begin with my questions about the profession. It was while trying to understand why archivists needed to do research, and how much research their work

[1] Kathleen Marquis, "Not Dragon at the Gate but Research Partner: The Reference Archivist as Mediator," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 36–37.

required, that I gradually saw how closely an understanding of the profession was connected to an understanding of archives.

1. Judgment in Preservation

I used to assess archivists mainly by whether users could obtain materials smoothly. This expectation had practical reasons, but it revealed only the results of their work. Before a document reaches a reader, someone needs to explain where it belongs, what it relates to, and why it is kept there. If these questions already have answers, finding materials can look like following a procedure. The problem is that the answers do not come attached to every document. The procedures themselves depend on archivists' understanding of the materials. This led me to examine the judgments involved in keeping and finding records, rather than treating them only as preparation for research.

My first response to "archivists as authors" reflected a similar limitation. To me, being an author primarily meant writing, so the phrase seemed to give another profession a form of creativity I associated with historians. But cartularies showed me that the overall form of a compilation already involved selecting and arranging existing texts. What was copied, how it was arranged, and how it was later supplemented could affect what the material could tell us. It could also contribute to property claims at the time. What Geary drew my attention to was therefore not whether archivists wrote stories as historians did, but how compilation had already established relationships that later researchers would use.[2]

However, simply accepting the label "author" did not mean I understood the work. Behind a cartulary were a bishop's authorization, a scribe's revisions, and later additions. A single name could not explain how it took shape. I found it more useful to ask what each person did, which arrangements survived, and which connections appeared later. From this perspective, archivists' research skills lay in making these specific distinctions. They needed to explain how materials were formed, rather than broadly claiming to participate in the

[2] Patrick Geary, "Medieval Archivists as Authors: Social Memory and Archival Memory," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 106–11.

production of history. A professional role I had found abstract became easier to understand through these questions.

Some judgments take place even before compilation and arrangement. I was initially used to selecting useful parts of existing materials for my own questions. I gave less thought to why a body of records was worth preserving from the keeper's perspective. Reading Cook reversed this order: choices made today affect what future researchers will be able to study. Assessing preservation value therefore requires understanding the activities that produced records and the social relationships they preserve. It cannot simply wait for researchers to express a need, because some materials may already be gone by then. The research questions archivists face thus differ from my own topic interests.[3]

This difference also explains why I cannot think of appraisal as guessing future research topics. People in the future may care about things that receive little attention today. Nor can I decide that a record has no preservation value simply because it is not currently useful to my question. Examining the functions and relationships that produced records offered another way to think: first understand what an activity left behind, then consider which opportunities for understanding might be lost through selection. Responsibility to the future does not require foreseeing the whole future. It does require understanding the objects of today's choices. I began to see why this work needed a historical perspective and involved demands different from those of completing a paper on a particular topic.

Arrangement also involves judgments I had not fully recognized. I once hoped that simple, consistent codes would make materials easier to find, so I tended to view catalogs as tools that could be improved. Yet a single item may concern different people and activities. Placing it under one name already highlights a particular relationship. Yakel's discussion of archival representation made me reconsider my expectation. Standards remain useful, but understanding a standard should also mean knowing what it makes easier to see. Otherwise,

[3] Terry Cook, "Remembering the Future: Appraisal of Records and the Role of Archives in Constructing Social Memory," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 169–70, 176–78.

the more convenient a catalog becomes, the more easily I may forget that someone organized the routes through which I search.[4]

Digital interfaces can make this work especially difficult to see. Entering keywords and receiving results can seem like a direct encounter between a user and materials. But the names used and the content described both depend on earlier understandings. If I find nothing, I need to distinguish between something never recorded, something not preserved, something not yet accessible, and a mismatch between my vocabulary and the catalog. Helping me identify these differences requires more than knowing file numbers. Recognizing the value of this help also changes how I ask questions: rather than only requesting a search result, I can ask about the route through which I am approaching the materials.

These questions gradually made me reconsider the sharp boundary I had drawn between management and research. Materials need proper care, and access needs to be arranged, but these tasks rest on a continuing understanding of the materials' origins and relationships. I used to imagine research as reaching a conclusion from materials. I now began to see that making materials understandable could itself require sustained work. This did not convince me that archivists and historians were no longer distinct. Instead, it made the distinction more worth examining: if both need to make judgments, what does each need to know, and how should they work together?

2. From Expecting Others to Understand to Learning to Work Together

Once I accepted that archivists needed to understand materials, I soon encountered another difficulty: how much understanding was enough? My initial answer was training that would make archivists more familiar with research questions and bring them closer to historians. This seemed straightforward, but it remained centered on the researcher, as though the other person needed to fill a knowledge gap before cooperation could begin. I did not also ask whether I understood the institutional processes that produced records or why catalog

[4] Elizabeth Yakel, "Archival Representation," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 151–53.

language differed from my questions. I gradually realized that expecting others to understand me better could also lead me to overlook what I needed to learn.

The example of nuclear medicine offered a concrete way through this difficulty. Marquis was unfamiliar with the researcher's field, yet was able to connect the topic to research in physics represented in the collection by asking questions. If cooperation had to wait until both sides possessed the same knowledge, this connection would have been difficult to make. Unfamiliarity did not only create an obstacle. It could also prompt people to explain questions they otherwise took for granted. I began to distinguish between two kinds of understanding: knowing all the content of a field and knowing how to ask questions and relate a problem to connections between materials. The latter could already make reference work useful to research.[5]

Seen this way, my original idea of training was incomplete. Collections cover many fields, and archivists cannot prepare for every question in advance. Researchers may know their own topics well without knowing how materials are organized. Their knowledge need not overlap completely. Archivists can help me understand a collection, while I need to explain my question clearly enough for discussion and judge whether a suggestion applies. The learning required for cooperation goes both ways. I cannot treat the other person's knowledge only as a resource for my needs. I also need to understand where that knowledge comes from and what it can answer.

My question about why archivists should explain evidential value also changed. I had made the task of interpretation too demanding in my mind, as though anyone who took part had to guarantee what a document said. I now prefer to understand this help through how materials were created, preserved, and altered. For example, in the Zhong Renjie case discussed by Bartlett, the complete survival of a confession does not mean that the person recorded described his experiences in his own way. Local officials' need to avoid blame for failing to detect the rebellion was connected to what the confession said. Recognizing this

[5] Marquis, "Not Dragon at the Gate but Research Partner," 38–39.

relationship helps us raise questions, but it still does not establish directly whether the uprising had been planned long in advance.[6]

This example helped me explain the responsibilities involved in cooperation. Someone who understands the system of record creation can identify the relationships within which a source needs to be read. Someone who uses it to offer a historical interpretation must still explain how those relationships support the argument. The two depend on each other, but neither can do all the other's work. Explaining a source's origins does not mean that an archivist is stepping beyond their role and reaching conclusions for me. My responsibility for the final judgment does not make that earlier explanation unimportant. My initial concern about overlapping professions gradually became a more specific question: how can different understandings be tested against each other?

I still care about why researchers would be willing to share their topics. An unfinished question may be difficult to explain, and researchers may not want to reveal all their plans. Partnership cannot therefore be built simply by demanding openness. An exchange can begin with a catalog term, the origins of a group of materials, or a specific search problem. Both sides can then decide whether to continue. My expectations of cooperation have become more limited but also more practical: willingness to hear advice is not a promise to accept it, and receiving help should not require giving up control of a research plan. Recognition of professional expertise and respect for voluntary participation can coexist.

Differences in understanding cannot necessarily be removed through communication. A connection an archivist sees within a collection may differ from my question. It may open a new direction, or it may need to be set aside. If I treat every difference as a failure of service, I am still asking the other person to guess my needs correctly. I now prefer to regard a suggestion as a judgment that has reasons and can be discussed. I can ask why it makes sense and then explain why I accept or reject it. Cooperation need not result in two people saying the same thing. Its value may instead lie in helping me understand more clearly what materials my question actually requires.

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[6] Beatrice S. Bartlett, "Qing Statesmen, Archivists, and Historians and the Question of Memory," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 422–23.

Looking back at these questions, I began to recognize the kinds of knowledge my research depended on. When I read the content of a source, I also needed to understand why it was preserved there and why it could be found in that way. Questions I once placed at the edge of research have now become part of my learning. I can therefore better understand why someone who raises these questions, studies them over time, and explains them to others can be seen as a research partner. The next question is how to turn this recognition into an understanding of a profession.

3. Historical Research as a Profession

As my understanding of archivists became clearer, I also began to reconsider what I counted as historical research. Asking questions, reading sources, and writing papers were the forms of research I knew best. Archival work showed me that research could also take the form of explaining the origins, structure, and relationships of a body of materials. This knowledge enters collection selection, catalog descriptions, and explanations for users. It may not appear as a paper on a particular topic, but it can affect how many different papers develop. I began to understand how the skills gained through historical training could become a sustained form of professional work.

This also made me take my initial image of archivists as managers more seriously. The administrative tasks I saw were real; I simply had not recognized the knowledge they required. Whether one item should be consulted alongside another, why they belong to different categories, and why certain content is temporarily unavailable may all require knowledge of how the materials were created and preserved. Answering these questions effectively requires connecting institutions, people, and specific activities. My view of the profession was limited not because I noticed everyday tasks, but because I imagined them as routine tasks with no research involved. I now want to make more effort to understand how judgment enters daily work.

Yet recognizing judgment does not mean imagining that archivists can decide everything through personal insight alone. When I read about the choice to preserve banned books against an order to destroy them, I valued the commitment to memory. But what someone could preserve also depended on their position, institutional requirements, and

conditions of supervision. This question in Bartlett's discussion made me see that an archivist's ability to act was not simply a matter of courage or conviction. I needed to notice both the choice a person made and why they had the opportunity to make it. Studying historical relationships therefore also involves understanding the limits of one's working conditions.[7]

Similarly, recognizing the need for professional judgment has not removed my questions about its basis. If preservation is to reflect social value, who decides what has value for society? Has a group's representative already expressed everyone's wishes about preservation? In *Activist Archives*, senior activists gain authority through their resources, while different groups later compete to represent the "'98 generation." This made Cook's account of responsibility more concrete for me: when considering materials for preservation, we need to study whose accounts are more likely to appear, rather than treating the most accessible version as a shared view.[8]

This question has not taken me back to wishing that archivists would only follow procedures. Procedures also depend on judgment, and avoiding personal responsibility does not remove selection. I would rather expect professionals to explain the basis of their understanding, the relationships they considered when making choices, and what they have not yet fully understood. Giving reasons and listening to other views are skills I now value. Historical training can support these skills, but specific archival practices also need to be learned. Considering archival work as a career therefore requires understanding its professional demands. The two jobs cannot simply be treated as interchangeable because both concern the past.

I also reconsidered what it means to "provide the conditions for others to do research." If a research outcome is understood only as an author's final interpretation, appraisal and description can appear to be assistance offered before that interpretation is completed. Yet the organization of a collection may support different questions at different times. Archivists need to understand present users while leaving room for unfamiliar

[7] Bartlett, "Qing Statesmen, Archivists, and Historians," 417–18.

[8] Doreen Lee, *Activist Archives: Youth Culture and the Political Past in Indonesia* (Duke University Press, 2016), 171–77, 186–88; Cook, "Remembering the Future," 169–70.

questions. I used to look for useful materials within a particular study. I am now trying to adopt another perspective and ask how a collection can support multiple studies. This shift in perspective helps me understand the work more than simply giving archivists the title of "researcher."

The career possibility I gradually came to see in these weeks therefore involved a research life different from the one I had imagined: sustained work with materials, continuing revision of how their relationships are understood, and explanation of that understanding to people with different needs. What drew my attention was the combination of independent judgment and communication, along with the need to consider personal interests in relation to wider uses. I still have much to learn about archival practice, but I can now understand why historical researchers might continue to use and develop their training in this field. My view has shifted from the service a user expects to the thinking the work itself requires.

My original questions have not ended at this point; they have taken another form. If archivists need to understand relationships between records and help judge their value, I cannot treat the "archives" they work with as objects whose status is already settled. We have considered preservation and description, but have not fully explained what should be preserved and described. In my earlier reading about activists' materials, paper, clothing, images, and living spaces had already made these boundaries unclear to me. I now want to raise that question again: what are archives? It concerns both what we call materials and what this profession studies and cares for.

4. From Document Lists to Records and Their Relationships

If I answered through the examples that used to come most readily to mind, archives would first mean a body of surviving documents. They contain readable information, enter a place of preservation, and then wait for researchers to use them. This understanding explains some materials, but it struggles to account for the records I encountered in activists' lives. They might be scattered during moves, copied as they circulated, or ordered to be destroyed. If I recognized archives only by whether they were already properly preserved, I would overlook much of what the materials did before they entered research. I therefore began to

wonder whether my definition depended too heavily on the condition in which later users could see them.

Paper first made this question concrete. I initially thought that words provided information while the paper itself was a relic of an earlier time. Yet poems and trial leaflets helped seek support, while discarded leaflets gained another chance to survive when Wilson picked them up. Both situations involved paper, but it was doing different things: connecting supporters and, after a decision to preserve it, becoming material for later users. Reading these experiences, I began to include copying, circulation, and collection in my understanding of records, rather than looking only at what was written on them.[9]

This also helped me let go of an expectation I had not noticed: records seemed always to be created in order to preserve history. Many materials first needed to serve a purpose in the present and only later became research objects through new questions. Archives can therefore connect different times: a record once took part in an activity and now helps others understand that activity. The two uses need not be the same. I find this more useful than simply expanding the range of materials beyond writing. What I need to explain is how the same trace enters different relationships, and why later preservation has not completely erased its earlier uses.

The discussion of "home" also made it difficult for me to define archives only through objects. Activists' temporary homes, organizational headquarters, and bases for action served as spaces for rest, interaction, and keeping materials. Roni could identify how the rooms in a former base had been used and remembered the regret of being unable to save documents from a fire. Housing was more than background outside the documents. Who could provide space and who sustained communal life affected whether records could be gathered and kept. But I do not want to treat the entire house as an archive on that basis. A more accurate understanding is that the documents' origins include these living relationships, which need to be made visible again when the documents are read.[10]

[9] Lee, *Activist Archives*, 25–30, 57–59.

[10] Lee, *Activist Archives*, 168–70.

I once wanted to know where records should be kept. I now ask an additional question: why could a particular place allow records to survive? An archival repository can provide conditions for preservation, and a shared living space may temporarily serve that purpose too. Their conditions and stability differ, but both remind me that the survival of materials depends on people's work. Seen this way, "what are archives?" is not only a question of recognizing the appearance of certain objects. It also requires explaining connections between objects, activities, and keepers. Institutional collections and activists' scattered materials can therefore be compared without first being treated as entirely separate worlds.

Images make these relationships clearer. When students lined up again to make a pledge for a journalist's camera, their self-presentation, the journalist's framing, and the imagined audience all helped produce the image. I can use it to study how a collective image was made, but I need to distinguish this scene from the original demonstration. What matters to me here is not only how truthful an image is, but what activity it actually records. If its production is ignored, an image worth studying may be mistaken for a direct record of something else. Recognizing it as archival material also requires keeping the contextual information that makes this distinction possible.[11]

The Singapore Stone discussed in class and the river sounds it reminded me of took this question further beyond writing and pictures. I am willing to recognize that these objects can help us understand the past, but still need to ask what has survived and on what basis it can be connected to an experience. Sound can be recorded and objects can be kept, yet later readers still need to know how the record was made and which relationships matter. My attitude toward archival boundaries has therefore changed: I am less quick to exclude unfamiliar forms, but am also not satisfied with simply saying that they carry memory. I want to explain more clearly the basis on which they can be studied.

I gradually moved from understanding archives as "lists of documents" toward understanding the relationships behind records. Archives can have different media and follow different paths of preservation. The shared question is how they allow an activity to remain

[11] Lee, *Activist Archives*, 181–82.

open to later understanding. Yet a difficulty remains: if an object carries many meanings, is that enough for it to count as archival material? My questions about originals and copies forced me to keep considering what I actually valued. Otherwise, I would merely be expanding the definition from familiar documents to everything with a value for memory, without explaining why it counts as archival material.

5. Identifying Archives and Understanding Their Meaning

I now tend to understand archives as records formed or left through particular activities that, through preservation and description, allow those activities to be understood again. This understanding first places records back in the relationships that produced them. It also recognizes that later people take part in selection and interpretation. It is not a complete definition that I have already mastered, but a way of checking my judgments after these readings. When I encounter a material, I need to explain which activity it relates to, how that connection was preserved, and how it can be recognized today. Saying only that it is old, important, or moving is not enough to answer these questions.

But an emphasis only on information could also make this understanding too narrow. I once asked why originals were still needed if their words had already been copied and circulated. Behind this question was a view of archives mainly as sources of content for researchers. Once the content had been copied, keeping the original seemed to mean only preservation costs. O'Toole's discussion of the original Declaration of Independence made this calculation difficult to maintain. Even when its writing was hard to read, the physical object could still matter in people's encounters with the past. I therefore also needed to explain why this particular original mattered, what it had experienced, and how people used it to establish a connection with the past.[12]

This did not lead me to conclude that "originals are always more valuable than copies." A textual copy and a physical original can support different questions. The former may make content easier to use; alterations, handwriting, and the preservation history of the

[12] James M. O'Toole, "Between Veneration and Loathing: Loving and Hating Documents," in *Archives, Documentation, and Institutions of Social Memory: Essays from the Sawyer Seminar*, ed. Francis X. Blouin Jr. and William G. Rosenberg (University of Michigan Press, 2006), 43–45.

latter may offer other clues. How an original is respected can itself be studied. I used to want to decide whether something was worth preserving through the amount of information it still contained. I now prefer first to clarify what I hope to understand through it. This change also connects to my view of archivists: keepers need to recognize different relationships in materials rather than treating them as replaceable containers of information.

The East German secret police archives also showed me that preservation cannot simply be equated with affection. People may hate the past that documents represent while wanting to keep them to hold people accountable. The fact that they become archives does not mean that their keepers approve of their original uses. Later use may instead change the relationship between records and society. If I understood archives only through what people wished to commemorate, I would struggle to explain this survival. The memories archives support need not inspire pride, and users need not share the same feelings. This helped me understand why identifying archives requires examining specific relationships rather than assuming a single motive for preservation.[13]

Similar questions appear in the secret preservation of banned books and in secret official archives. Materials can be in state custody without fitting the public narrative. They can survive without being widely accessible. After reading Bartlett, I find it harder to decide whose memory a collection represents simply from the identity of its keeper. Why it exists there, and what limits apply separately to preservation and use, help me understand it more than first classifying it as official or nonofficial. This also made me revise the intuition that materials become archives only after entering an archival institution. Institutional location matters, but it cannot replace an understanding of what records have gone through.[14]

At the same time, recognizing that selection and use change meaning does not allow researchers to call everything archives at will. A home can help explain the conditions in which documents were formed, but this role alone cannot make it evidence for any experience. Clothing can show attempts to express identity without directly revealing everyone's inner beliefs. I now prefer to keep these distinctions. An object may have heritage

[13] O'Toole, "Between Veneration and Loathing," 43–45.

[14] Bartlett, "Qing Statesmen, Archivists, and Historians," 417–18.

or commemorative value and may also be studied as a record in relation to a particular question, but these uses need separate explanation. As the range of archives expands, both archivists and users need to make clearer which connections they are establishing.

Some connections also prevent me from understanding preservation only through researchers' needs. The document ordered to be burned after reading, yet still preserved, offers a trace for later study while also retaining the demand for secrecy at the time. Its survival alone cannot tell me how the order was carried out. Nor would I assume that the people involved should have preserved everything simply because we can use it today. The formation of archives involves choices and the circumstances of those who created records. Preservation, access, and use may therefore require different conditions. Understanding what a material is also requires knowing why it was supposed to be treated in a particular way.[15]

Rethinking "what are archives?" has ultimately made me more cautious and more willing to learn about particular objects. I no longer judge only by medium or place of custody, nor do I think a shared emotional meaning explains all materials. Connections between records and activities, processes of preservation and description, and the questions that can later be asked all need to be considered together. This understanding still needs to be tested against different materials, but it has already changed my view of the profession. Archivists do not work with a list of items whose meanings have already been settled. Understanding why they become archives is itself research that the profession continually requires.

[15] Lee, *Activist Archives*, 44–45.

Conclusion

Returning to my initial questions, I can now better explain why archivists need to understand materials. They need to know not only what documents say, but also how records were formed, why they were preserved, and how different people can use them. My change lies in moving from judging the profession only through users' needs toward trying to understand its judgments from within the work. I no longer expect partnership to depend on archivists fully mastering every study. Instead, I am willing to learn from their knowledge and consider how my questions can become part of an exchange. This is an understanding I have gradually developed during these weeks and still need to put into practice.

The possibility of archival work as another career direction for historical researchers therefore has a concrete meaning for me. Historical training can be used to interpret part of the past. It can also be used to study and care for the materials that make such interpretation possible. The latter work requires professional methods, communication skills, and an understanding of the consequences of judgment. Recognizing these demands allows me to consider the career seriously, rather than simply thinking that it also concerns history. When I use archives in the future, I hope to turn this understanding into better questions and to acknowledge in my arguments the work and knowledge supporting my research.

The question "what are archives?" extends this understanding of the profession. I now prefer to begin with relationships between records and activities, including how objects survive and how they are described and used. Archivists' roles and the scope of archives are therefore connected: changing objects require new understandings, while professional judgments shape how later people understand those objects. I still cannot give a single answer that applies to every kind of material without exception, but I now know which relationships to ask about. For me, this is where my thinking has moved forward: the person I once saw as only keeping documents has gradually become a professional who needs to understand history and helps others understand it too.

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